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CHRISTMAS 2026 EDITION

WILEY FOX TRAVEL  
FAMILIES AND SOLO TRAVELLERS

THE WILEY FOX GUIDE TO

# Vienna

*For families & solo travellers*

4

WILEY FOX RATING • LOW

OUT OF 5 • POLICE DATA JAN 2025 TO DEC 2025

CREATOR FEELING 5/5 • VERY SAFE AND CALM - CROWDED AT THE BIG MARKETS

## 13 Nov

RATHAUSPLATZ MARKET OPENS

To 26 December 2026, 10:00-22:00 (24 Dec to 18:30). Schönbrunn and Stephansplatz open on 6 November.

## 20+

OFFICIAL ADVENT MARKETS

Most close on 23 December; Schönbrunn and the Prater winter market run to 6 January 2027.

50

CREATORS • 78 VIDEOS

Paraphrased and credited, cross-checked with official sources.

*Vienna's historic centre, the Innere Stadt (1st district), sits inside the Ringstraße, the grand boulevard that replaced the city walls. Inside or on the Ring are St Stephen's Cathedral, the Hofburg palace, the State Opera, the City Hall and the big museums; Schönbrunn Palace, the Belvedere and the Prater amusement park are a short U-Bahn or tram ride out. The city is flat, clean and easy on public transport, and the 23 districts are numbered, which makes addresses simple. Creators suggest three or four days.*

At Christmas Vienna has more than 20 official Advent markets, each with its own character. The Christkindlmarkt in front of the City Hall is the famous one, with an ice-skating trail through the trees and a children's world in the park; Schönbrunn is the family favourite; Art Advent at Karlsplatz has a hay pit, farm animals and a hand-turned carousel; Spittelberg, Am Hof and Freyung are where locals go. The shopping streets are hung with giant chandeliers, and coffee houses, cake and Christmas concerts fill the gaps between markets.

For solo travellers Vienna feels safe and relaxed, and transport runs all night at weekends. Plan for heavy crowds at the big markets on weekend evenings, stalls that want cash, shops closed on Sundays and on 25 and 26 December, cold, grey weather, and 2026 changes to tickets and airport trains (see Getting around).

WF

Austria doesn't publish street-level crime data, so before you book, check your hotel's street on the Wiley Fox map and in community reports – especially if a deal is near Praterstern, Westbahnhof or Reumannplatz.

*Fast facts*

**CURRENCY** Euro (EUR) - cards work in most shops, but many market stalls, cafés and toilets want cash or coins; avoid Euronet cash machines, which charge high fees

LANGUAGE German (Austrian) - English is widely spoken in the centre

TIME\_ZONE Central European Time (UTC+1) - one hour ahead of the UK

PLUG Type C and F, 230V - UK plugs need an adaptor

EMERGENCY 112 all services · 133 police · 144 ambulance · 122 fire

ENTRY UK passport issued less than 10 years before arrival and valid 3+ months after you leave the Schengen area; up to 90 days in any 180. EES fingerprint and photo checks at the border since October 2025 (gov.uk)

**TIPPING** About 5-10%, by rounding up: tell the waiter the total you want to pay rather than leaving coins on the table

**BEST TIME** The Advent markets from mid-November, on weekday afternoons; most close on 23 December

## THE FESTIVE SEASON

## Christmas in Vienna

Vienna has more than 20 official Advent markets, from the famous Christkindlmarkt in front of the City Hall to small ones in parks, lanes and university courtyards. Each serves Punsch and Glühwein in its own mug, and many have rides, workshops or animals for children. The first open on 6 November 2026; most close on 23 December, and a few run into January. Police step up uniformed and plain-clothes patrols every Advent.

### Christmas markets



Photo: Palickap · CC BY-SA 4.0



#### Wiener Christkindlmarkt (Rathausplatz)

INNERE STADT • 13 NOV - 26 DEC 2026 • 10:00-22:00 • 24 DEC TO 18:30 • GREAT FOR KIDS

The big one: about 100 stalls in front of the floodlit City Hall, a winding ice-skating trail through the park (to 6 January, closed 31 December), a two-tier carousel, a reindeer train, a nativity trail and a flying-heart light show over the trees every half hour after dark. Food includes Käsekrainer, langos, potato pancakes and Kaiserschmarrn in a cone. Lockers and toilets on site.

**Crowds:** The most crowded market in Vienna - creators found it hard to move on a Saturday. Go at opening or an hour before closing on a weekday; the back sections are calmer.

Via [Happy to Wander](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Traveling Expats](#), [Pursuing Mountains](#), [Dave Mani](#), [Bon Voyage Brenda](#), [The Endless Adventure](#), [Frosty Summer](#), [Khyati & Puria](#)

*Free entry · Glühwein averaged about €6.25 + mug deposit (2024)*

DETAILS



Photo: Funke · CC BY-SA 4.0



## Schönbrunn Palace

HIETZING · 6 NOV 2026 - 6 JAN 2027 · 10:00-21:00 · 24 DEC TO 16:00 · FROM 25 DEC 10:00-19:00 · GREAT FOR KIDS

Creators' favourite for families: more than 90 stalls in the palace courtyard, a big tree, a small ice rink that is free for children, curling, a carousel, a Ferris wheel and a children's train, with concerts on the stage. Raclette is the dish - pay first, then queue for it. It runs on as a New Year market.

**Crowds:** Busy but manageable; school groups on weekday mornings, calmest in the evening when day-trippers leave. U4 to Schönbrunn.

Via [Traveling Expats](#), [Sonia Mota: Simply Slow Traveler](#), [Pursuing Mountains](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Probably Lost](#), [Frosty Summer](#), [Khyati & Puria](#)

*Free entry · Glühwein a little cheaper than in the centre (2023)*

DETAILS

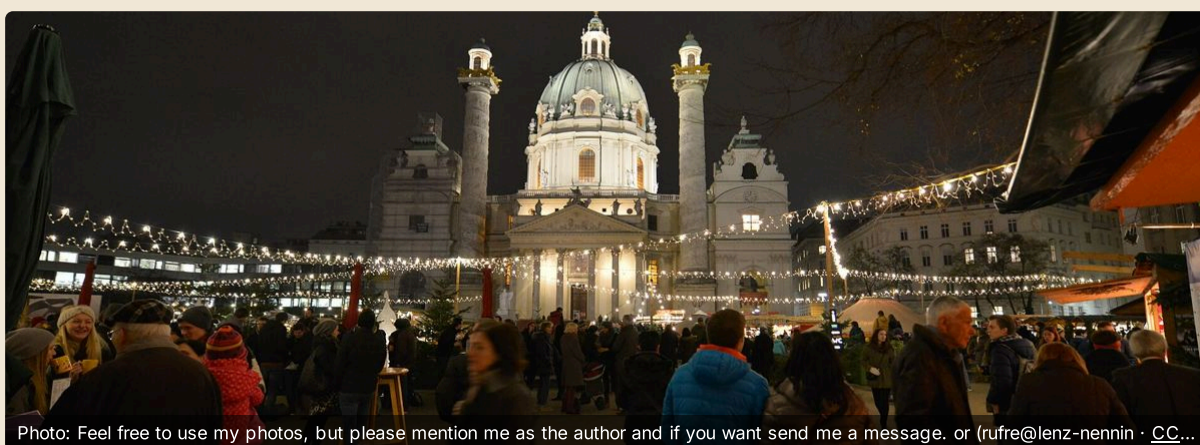


Photo: Feel free to use my photos, but please mention me as the author and if you want send me a message. or ([rufre@lenz-nennin](mailto:rufre@lenz-nennin)) · CC...



## Art Advent (Karlsplatz)

WIEDEN · 13 NOV - 23 DEC 2026 · 12:00-20:00 (FOOD TO 21:00) · GREAT FOR KIDS

Handmade-only crafts chosen by a jury, in front of the Karlskirche, with organic food. The best children's area in the city, creators say: a hay pit, a pedal-powered train, a hand-turned carousel and farm animals to stroke, plus craft workshops.

**Crowds:** Busy at weekends, but more local than the Rathaus.

Via [Pursuing Mountains](#), [Traveling Expats](#), [Worthy Travels](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Frosty Summer](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Khyati & Puria](#)

*Free entry · mug deposit about €4 (2024)*

DETAILS



Photo: Geolina163 · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

## Spittelberg

NEUBAU · 13 NOV - 23 DEC 2026 · MON-FRI 14:00-21:30 · WEEKENDS 11:00-21:30

More than 100 stalls through narrow cobbled lanes and courtyards behind the MuseumsQuartier: crafts, raclette, wild-boar sausage and many Punsch flavours. The market locals use after work – youthful and a bit adult in the evening.

**Crowds:** Busy after work and at weekends; opens only at 2pm on weekdays.

Via [Traveling Expats](#), [Frosty Summer](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Pursuing Mountains](#), [Jess Ellis](#), [VIENNA CALLING - Travel Guide](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Bon Voyage Brenda](#)

*Punsch about €4.50 · mug deposit about €3 (2024)*

DETAILS



Photo: Palickap · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

## Am Hof

INNERE STADT • 13 NOV - 23 DEC 2026 • MON-THU 11:00-21:00 • FRI-SUN 10:00-21:00 • GREAT FOR KIDS

A market has been held on this square since 1762. Crafts on one side and food on the other - raclette potatoes (€13 in 2025), soup in a bread bowl, Käsespätzle - with a lit canopy and a champagne bar.

**Crowds:** Calmer than the big three.

Via [Frosty Summer](#), [Alex Mark Travel](#), [Probably Lost](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [VIENNA CALLING - Travel Guide](#)

*Free entry*

DETAILS



Photo: Johann Werfring · [CC BY-SA 3.0](#)

## *Altwiener Christkindlmarkt (Freyung)*

INNERE STADT • 14 NOV - 23 DEC 2026 • 10:00-21:00 • GREAT FOR KIDS

A small, old-style market of about 60 stalls with wooden toys, ornaments, a large nativity and live music, two minutes from Am Hof. Kaiserschmarrn from about €8 (2025).

**Crowds:** Quiet and peaceful - much calmer than the Rathaus.

Via [Frosty Summer](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Probably Lost](#), [Alex Mark Travel](#), [Vienna](#), [Worthy Travels](#)

*Free entry*

DETAILS



Photo: Geolina163 · CC BY-SA 4.0

## ***Maria-Theresien-Platz***

INNERE STADT • 20 NOV - 26 DEC 2026 • MON-FRI 11:00-21:00 • WEEKENDS 10:00-21:00 • GREAT FOR KIDS

About 70 stalls between the Natural History and Art History museums, with drinks in boot-shaped mugs and good handmade gifts. Lovely at sunset; pair it with the dinosaurs next door.

**Crowds:** Very busy at weekends; calmer on weekday daytimes.

Via [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Traveling Expats](#), [GoAnnieWhere](#), [Probably Lost](#), [Bon Voyage Brenda](#)

*Free entry · potato fritters about €7 (2024)*

DETAILS

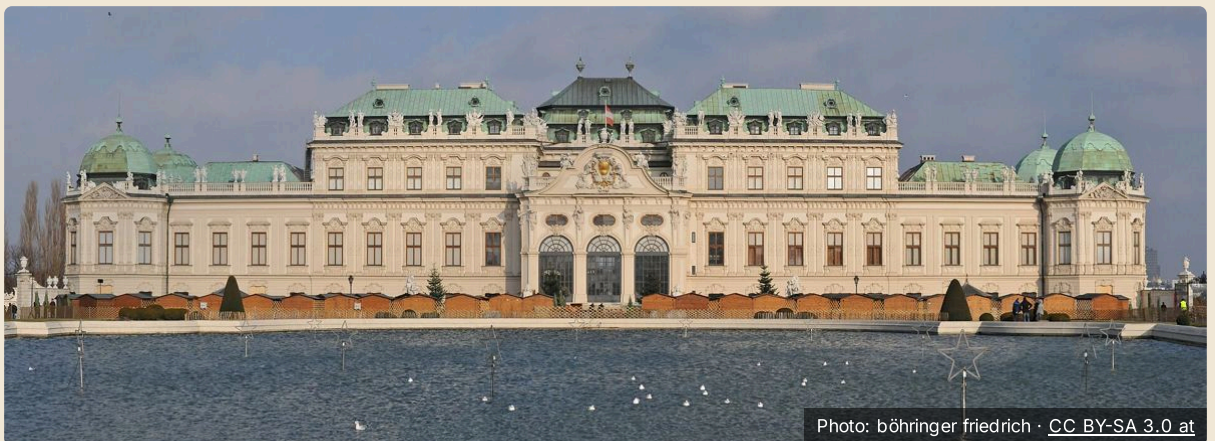


Photo: böhringer friedrich · CC BY-SA 3.0 at

## ***Belvedere***

LANDSTRASSE • 20 NOV - 31 DEC 2026 • MON-FRI 11:00-21:00 • WEEKENDS 10:00-21:00 • 24 & 31 DEC TO 17:00 • GREAT FOR KIDS

Up to 35 stalls in front of the Upper Belvedere, reflected in the pond - one of the prettiest settings and quieter because it is a little out. Kaiserschmarrn was about €11 (2024).

**Crowds:** Not very crowded; peaceful at night.

Via [Traveling Expats](#), [Frosty Summer](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Dave Mani](#), [Bon Voyage Brenda](#)

*Free entry*

DETAILS



Photo: Geolina163 · CC BY-SA 4.0

## *Stephansplatz*

INNERE STADT • 6 NOV - 26 DEC 2026 • 11:00-21:00 • 24 DEC TO 16:00 • 25-26 DEC TO 19:00

About 40 stalls at the foot of the cathedral - soup in bread and boot mugs, and the cathedral to warm up in. Creators found it pretty but small and pricey.

**Crowds:** Hardly room to move on a Saturday night; quiet on Sunday.

Via [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Pursuing Mountains](#), [GoAnnieWhere](#), [Bon Voyage Brenda](#), [Frosty Summer](#)

*Free entry*

DETAILS



Photo: Ziarko j · CC BY-SA 3.0 at

## *Altes AKH university campus*

ALSERGRUND • 13 NOV - 23 DEC 2026 • WEEKDAYS FROM 14:00, SAT FROM 11:00 • TO 22:00-23:00 • GREAT FOR KIDS

In the courtyard of the old general hospital, now the university: students and locals, curling lanes, children's entertainment and often cheaper drinks. Open latest - a good place to end the evening.

**Crowds:** Much less crowded than the centre.

Via [Frosty Summer](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Pursuing Mountains](#), [VIENNA CALLING](#) - Travel Guide

*Free entry*

DETAILS



Photo: Ursularegina · [CC BY-SA 3.0 at](#)

## ***Türkenschanzpark***

WÄHRING · 14 NOV - 23 DEC 2026 · MON-FRI 15:00-22:00 · WEEKENDS 12:00-22:00  
· GREAT FOR KIDS

A small market hidden in a park, beautifully lit, with a children's craft workshop at weekends. Germknödel (yeast dumpling with poppy seed) is the dish.

**Crowds:** Quiet - off the tourist trail.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#)

*Free entry*

DETAILS

## ***Prater winter market (Riesenradplatz)***

LEOPOLDSTADT · 20 NOV 2026 - 6 JAN 2027 · FROM 12:00 WEEKDAYS, 11:00  
WEEKENDS, TO 22:00 · GREAT FOR KIDS

Stalls round the giant Ferris wheel with langos and BuchteIn, fairground rides and live music in the evening. Good for families; the Prater's free Krampus parade in early December gets very crowded.

**Crowds:** Quieter by day.

Via [Alp Galip Travels](#), [Frosty Summer](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Happy to Wander](#)

*Free entry · rides extra*

DETAILS

## Lights, rinks and festive sights



Photo: Photo: Andreas Praefcke · [CC BY 3.0](#)

### *The Graben and Kohlmarkt lights*

INNERE STADT · FROM MID-NOVEMBER, AFTER DARK · GREAT FOR KIDS

Giant chandeliers of 250,000 LEDs hang over the Graben, with a huge red bow on Kohlmarkt. Mariahilfer Straße and the Ring are lit too. Go late in the evening when the shopping crowds thin.

**Crowds:** Very busy early evening.

Via [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Frosty Summer](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Khyati & Puria](#)

*Free*

DETAILS

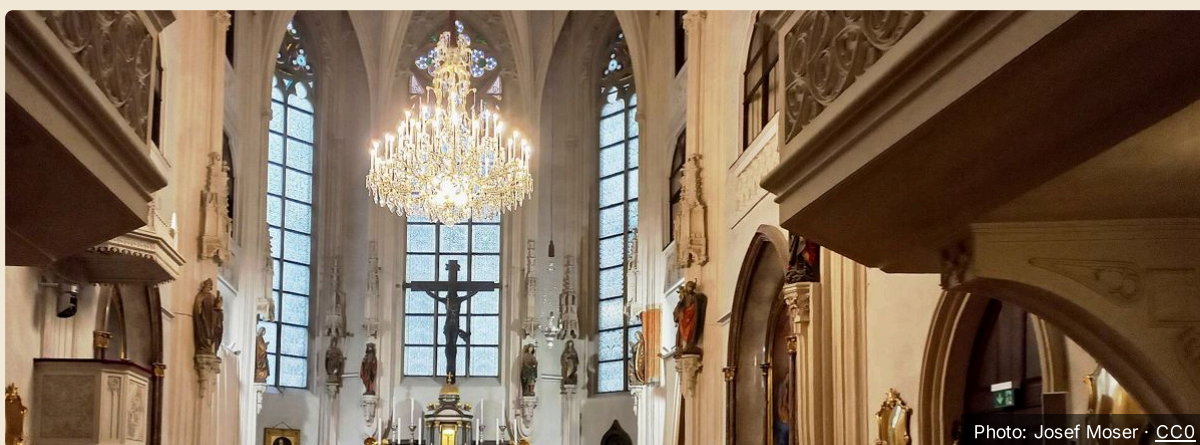


Photo: Josef Moser · [CC0](#)

### *Vienna Boys' Choir at the Hofburg Chapel*

HOFBURG · SUNDAYS IN ADVENT AND 25 DEC 2026, 09:15 · GREAT FOR KIDS

The choir sings Sunday Mass in the Hofburgkapelle. It is a church service with limited seats - book ahead for a seat or arrive early for standing room.

**Crowds:** Limited places.

Source: Austrian police / official sources

*Check the site*

DETAILS



## *Skating*

RATHAUSPLATZ & SCHÖNBRUNN • RATHAUSPLATZ RINK 13 NOV - 6 JAN • CLOSED 31 DEC  
• GREAT FOR KIDS

The skating trail at the Christkindlmarkt winds between the trees of the Rathauspark; tickets from machines on site. Schönbrunn's rink is free for children. The bigger Wiener Eistraum on the same square only opens on 22 January 2027.

**Crowds:** Busiest at weekends.

Via [Walking & Relax](#), [Dave Mani](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Vienna](#)

*Pay at the machines*

DETAILS

## *New Year's Eve trail (Silvesterpfad)*

INNERE STADT & PRATER • 31 DEC 2026, 14:00 - 02:00 • GREAT FOR KIDS

A free party along eight squares from the Rathaus to Stephansplatz and the Prater, with the Pummerin bell and the Blue Danube waltz at midnight. Rockets and bangers are banned in Vienna. In 2025 pushchairs and dogs were kept out of the busiest areas and Stephansplatz U-Bahn closed from 21:00.

**Crowds:** About 550,000 people in 2025; areas close when full.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#)

*Free*

DETAILS

# *Staying safe in the Christmas crowds*

## ***Crowds and timing***

Creators advise avoiding the big markets on weekends. Weekday afternoons, opening time and the last hour are calmest.

Rathausplatz and Stephansplatz are the pinch points; Freyung, Am Hof, Belvedere and the campus market are relaxed.

Via [Pursuing Mountains](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Traveling Expats](#)

## ***Police at the markets***

In November 2025 the Interior Minister said police would again show increased presence at the Advent markets, with uniformed and plain-clothes officers and specialist units, and that there was no sign of a specific threat. The UK Foreign Office says terrorists are likely to try to attack in Austria. The 2026 plan is usually announced in November.

Source: Austrian police / official sources

## ***Pickpockets***

Police call Advent the high season for pickpockets. Thieves bump into you, spill a drink or wave a card or flyer to distract you. Keep valuables in a zipped inner pocket, carry little cash, and block your cards straight away if anything goes.

Via [Wolters World](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#)

## ***Mugs, cash and food prices***

Drinks come in a mug with a deposit of about €3-5. In 2024 Punsch cost €4.50-10.50 and Glühwein €4.80-7.50; market food is mostly €5-15. Many stalls are cash only, and market toilets cost about 50 cents.

Via [Alex Mark Travel](#), [Traveling Expats](#), [The Endless Adventure](#), [Alp Galip Travels](#), [Bon Voyage Brenda](#)

## ***Have a lost-child plan***

Before you go in, agree a meeting point everyone can find - the carousel at Rathausplatz or the big tree at Schönbrunn. A Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child means anyone who finds them can reach you straight away.

Source: Austrian police / official sources

## ***Cold and slippery***

December evenings are around 0°C with an icy wind, and the old-town cobbles get slippery. Waterproof shoes with grip, gloves and a hat; take warm drinks slowly with children.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [Maya Fitzherbert](#)

In 2026 Schönbrunn and Stephansplatz open on 6 November and the Rathausplatz Christkindlmarkt on 13 November. Most markets close on 23 December; Rathausplatz, Stephansplatz and Maria-Theresien-Platz run to 26 December, the Belvedere to 31 December, and Schönbrunn and the Prater winter market to 6 January. On 24 December the markets that stay open close early, and general shops shut at 14:00; shops are closed on 25 and 26 December. Book palaces, cafés and Christmas concerts early.

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Clip a Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child. If you get separated in the crowd at Rathausplatz or on the U-Bahn, anyone who scans it can contact you straight away - no app needed on their side.

## WHAT THE DATA AND THE CREATORS SAY

*How it feels, and what the numbers show**The data*

Vienna is one of Europe's calmer capitals, and creators - solo women and families included - felt safe day and night. The risk visitors are most likely to meet is theft in crowds. Austrian police recorded 5,448 pickpocketing and trick-theft cases in Vienna in 2025, down 8% on 2024: about 267 per 100,000 residents, compared with about 99 for Austria as a whole, and Vienna has six in ten of the country's cases. All reported crime was about 9,530 per 100,000 residents, flat on 2024 - above Munich (5,798) and well below Berlin (13,642), though Austria and Germany count slightly differently. Rates are per resident and do not count the millions of visitors. A few small areas have weapon-ban zones because of drug-related trouble - Praterstern, around Reumannplatz in Favoriten and Yppenplatz - none of them on the usual market route. The UK Foreign Office says terrorists are likely to try to attack in Austria and that police presence is higher; four people were killed in a shooting in central Vienna in November 2020. This rating is for the city as a whole: Austria does not publish street-level crime data.

*The creators*

Creators call Vienna one of the safest cities they have visited. Expats who walk home alone late at night say they have always felt safe and see plenty of police, and families found it easy with children. The complaints are crowds at Rathausplatz and Stephansplatz on weekend evenings - one called the Rathausplatz market a public-health hazard on a Saturday - cash-only stalls, costumed sellers pushing overpriced concerts, steep fines on public transport, and a few places that feel rougher after dark: Praterstern, and Reumannplatz and Keplerplatz in Favoriten.

*What the official figures say*

Figures are from the Bundeskriminalamt (Austria's federal criminal police office) report on offences reported to police in 2025, published on 31 March 2026. Vienna is both a city and a federal state, so these are city figures. Rates per 100,000 are Wiley Fox's

calculations using Statistik Austria's provisional population for 1 January 2026 (Vienna 2,042,036). 2025 in Vienna: all reported offences 194,625 (-0.2%), pickpocketing and trick theft 5,448 (-7.8%), robbery 1,369 (-1.8%), violent offences 31,430 (+1.4%, a broad category that includes domestic violence). The report does not give Vienna figures for assault on its own or for home burglary, and Austria publishes no district or street-level crime data, so this guide's map shows the markets, sights and the police zones named in official orders. On New Year's Eve 2025/26 about 550,000 people joined the Silvesterpfad; organisers closed the area shortly before midnight because it was full, and police reported no notable incidents.

**-8%**

PICKPOCKETING AND TRICK THEFT (2025)

5,448 cases in Vienna, about 267 per 100,000 residents; Austria about 99. Falling since 2016 (Bundeskriminalamt).

**9,530**

ALL REPORTED OFFENCES PER 100,000 RESIDENTS (2025)

Flat on 2024. Munich 5,798, Berlin 13,642 (own reports); counting rules differ slightly.

**550,000**

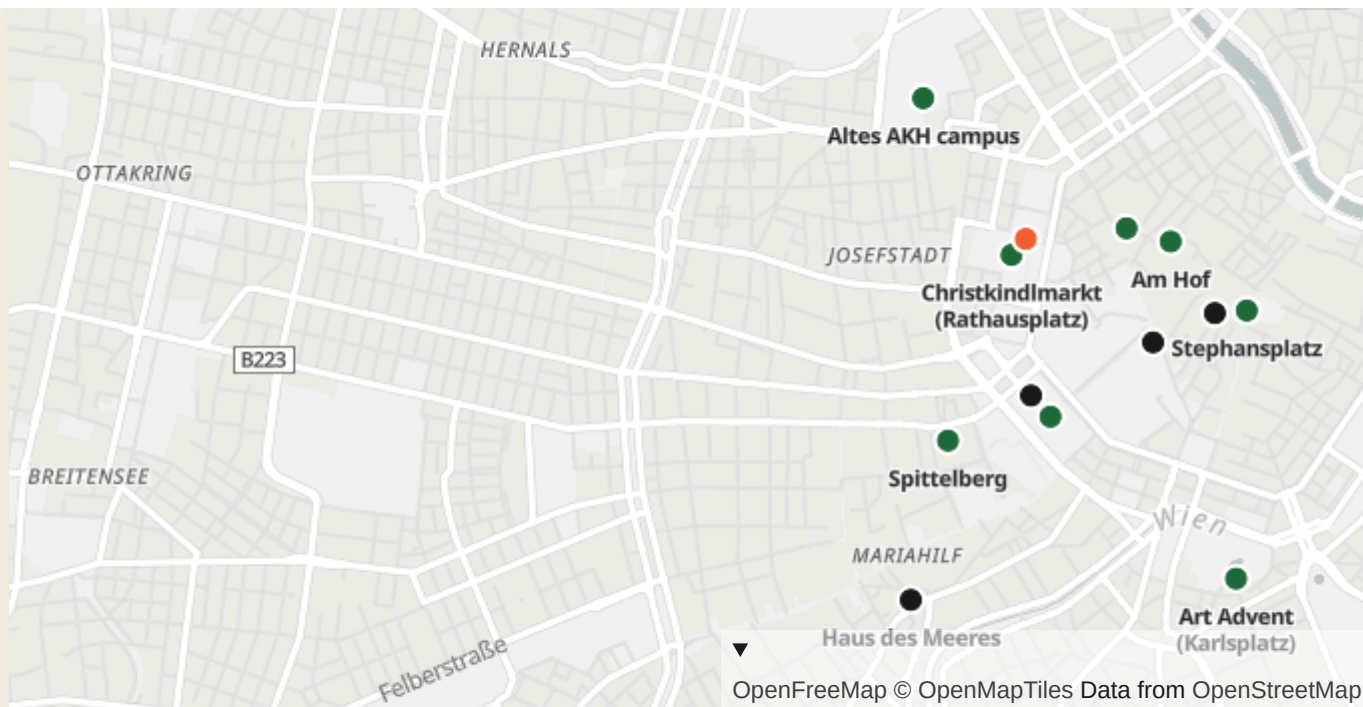
PEOPLE AT THE 2025 NEW YEAR'S EVE TRAIL

Police reported no notable incidents; the area was closed shortly before midnight when full (City of Vienna).

## *Map: markets, sights and places to take care*

Austria doesn't publish street-level crime data, so this map shows the markets and sights in this guide, the busiest crowd spots and the police zones named in official orders.





#### Pins

● Christmas market
 ● Sight or base
 ● Take extra care

Crime figures: Bundeskriminalamt - Kriminalpolizeiliche Anzeigenstatistik 2025 · [Open the Wiley Fox map](#)

## How Vienna compares with the rest of Austria

Offences reported to police in 2025 per 100,000 residents. Austria publishes these figures by federal state, and Vienna is the only state that is a single city - so the other rows include their cities (Graz, Linz, Salzburg, Innsbruck) and the countryside around them. Vienna is higher on both lines, as capital cities are, because visitors and commuters are counted as victims but not as residents.

|                             | ALL REPORTED OFFENCES | PICKPOCKETING & TRICK THEFT |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------|
| Upper Austria (incl. Linz)  | 4,343                 | 46                          |
| Styria (incl. Graz)         | 4,824                 | 58                          |
| Tyrol (incl. Innsbruck)     | 5,501                 | 39                          |
| Salzburg state (incl. city) | 5,701                 | 55                          |
| <b>Vienna</b>               | <b>9,531</b>          | <b>267</b>                  |
| <i>Austria average</i>      | <i>5,843</i>          | <i>99</i>                   |

per 100,000 residents, 2025 (Wiley Fox calculation)

Rates are Wiley Fox's calculations from the Bundeskriminalamt counts and Statistik Austria's provisional population for 1 January 2026; the report's own rates use a slightly different population base. City-only figures for Graz,

Linz, Salzburg and Innsbruck are not published in the report. For a German comparison: Munich recorded 5,798 and Berlin 13,642 offences per 100,000 residents in 2025, but the two countries count slightly differently. Source: [Bundeskriminalamt - Kriminalpolizeiliche Anzeigenstatistik 2025](#)

## *Areas to take extra care*

None of these are no-go areas. Know the pattern, and plan your timing and your route home.

- **Rathausplatz, Stephansplatz and the Graben**

TAKE MOST CARE: WEEKEND AFTERNOONS AND EVENINGS

The most crowded places in the city at Christmas. Police warned in November 2025 that Advent is the high season for pickpockets, especially in crowds, at stalls and in queues, using bumping, spilt drinks and cards or flyers as distractions. Keep bags zipped and in front, carry little cash, and agree a meeting point with children.

Via [Pursuing Mountains](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Happy to Wander](#)

- **Praterstern station square**

TAKE MOST CARE: EVENINGS AND NIGHT

The square in front of the station feels rough at night, creators say. It is a police weapon-ban zone (current order to 7 December 2026) and alcohol is banned there; 95 weapons were seized in 2024. Fine by day and for the Prater and Riesenrad - just don't linger at night.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [City Zen](#), [Traveling Butler](#)

- **Reumannplatz and Keplerplatz (Favoriten)**

TAKE MOST CARE: AFTER DARK

Lively by day, with the Viktor-Adler-Markt and good food, but creators describe drug and alcohol activity after dark. Parts are a police weapon-ban zone. Not on the tourist route; the Hauptbahnhof a few hundred metres away feels quite different.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [City Zen](#)

## ● Westbahnhof and Gumpendorfer Straße

TAKE MOST CARE: EVENINGS

Police set up an alcohol ban and protection zone around Fritz-Imhoff-Park by the U6 in May 2026 and run regular checks at the station. Fine for a train or the hotels in the station complex; stay on the main streets at night.

Source: Austrian police / official sources

## ● Ticket inspections on the U-Bahn, trams and buses

TAKE MOST CARE: ALWAYS

There are no barriers, but plain-clothes inspectors check often, and an unvalidated paper ticket counts as no ticket. The penalty is about €130-135 on the spot. App tickets need no validating.

Via [Carol & Max](#), [Wolters World](#), [Grete the Austrian Guide](#), [Ria SW](#), [Borja Ilegó](#)

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Most markets close at 9 or 10pm and the U-Bahn runs all night at weekends. Save your hotel on Wiley Fox and keep SOS one tap away on the way back.

## *Scams and tricks creators keep seeing*

### *Costumed concert sellers*

People in Mozart-era costume sell tickets for tourist concerts, often in small rooms, around Stephansplatz and the State Opera. One creator says the city banned them from those squares from July 2026. Buy from the venue's own website instead.

Via [VIENNA CALLING - Travel Guide](#), [Borja Ilegó](#), [Carol & Max](#)

### *Petition and charity collectors*

On the Graben near the cathedral, collectors ask for your name and email and then press for a donation. Walk on.

Via [Borja Ilegó](#)

### *Helpers at ticket machines and street games*

### *Fee-heavy cash machines*

Euronet and other independent cash machines charge high fees and dynamic

Politely refuse strangers offering to help at station ticket machines - use the staffed counter. Three-card games have been seen near the Naschmarkt; stay clear.

Via [Wolters World](#)

currency conversion. Use a bank's machine and always pay in euros.

Via [VIENNA CALLING - Travel Guide](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Borja Ilegó](#)

### ***Bills on a night out***

In clubs and bars, watch the card terminal and check the amount before you tap - a creator saw terminals turned away from customers.

Via [Borja Ilegó](#)

## NEIGHBOURHOODS

*Where to stay*

Pick an area first, then a hotel. The old town is compact, so most bases are within a short walk of the markets.

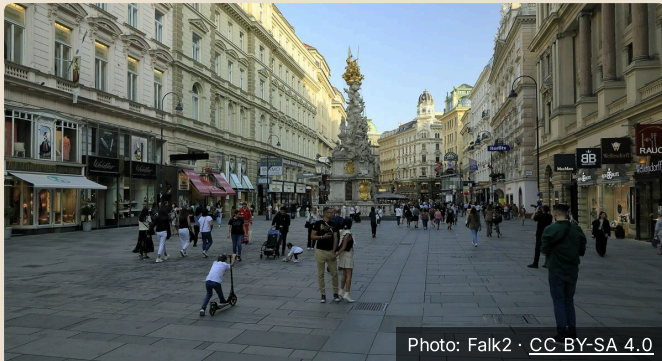


Photo: Falk2 · CC BY-SA 4.0

*Innere Stadt (1st district)*

FIRST-TIMERS • CHRISTMAS MARKETS • WALKING

Inside the Ring, walkable to the cathedral, Hofburg, Opera and five of the markets, so you can drop back to the hotel between them. Creators found it safe and convenient but the priciest area: doubles about €200-300 a night against €120-150 a few districts out (2024).

Via [Travel Tips Group](#), [Alp Galip Travels](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [TRIP XTREME](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#)



Photo: Isival · CC BY-SA 3.0

*Neubau & Spittelberg (7th)*

COUPLES • SOLO TRAVELLERS • FOOD

The creative district behind the MuseumsQuartier, with independent shops, cafés and the cobbled lanes of the Spittelberg market. Cheaper than the 1st district, with the U2 and U3 and a short walk to Maria-Theresien-Platz.

Via [Travel Tips Group](#), [TRIP XTREME](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Exotic Vacation](#)



Photo: Michael Kranewitter · CC BY-SA 4.0



Photo: C. Stadler/Bwag · CC BY-SA 4.0

*Leopoldstadt (2nd)*

## *Josefstadt & Alsergrund (8th and 9th)*

QUIET NIGHTS • FAMILIES • COFFEE HOUSES

Calm, elegant streets about ten minutes' walk from the centre, with traditional coffee houses and the student Christmas market in the Altes AKH courtyard.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [City Zen](#)

FAMILIES • BUDGET • PARKS

Ranked the best family district by one couple who live there: the Prater, the Augarten and the Riesenrad winter market, with the U1 and U2. Mid-range hotels about \$150-220 a night (2026). Most of it is green and quiet, but the small zone around Praterstern station feels rougher at night and is a police weapon-ban zone - pick a hotel away from the station square.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [City Zen](#), [TRIP XTREME](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#), [The Traveler's Atlas](#)



Photo: Diego Delso · CC BY-SA 4.0

## *Wieden & Landstraße (4th and 3rd)*

GOOD VALUE • ARRIVING BY TRAIN • FAMILIES

Just south and east of the Ring: Karlsplatz, the Belvedere and the Hauptbahnhof, with mid-range hotels about \$120-180 a night near the station (2026). Quiet and residential, and the Belvedere gardens are free to walk.

Via [Senior Travel World](#), [The Traveler's Atlas](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#), [City Zen](#)



Photo: Manfred Werner (Tsui) · CC BY-SA 4.0

## *Near any U-Bahn station further out*

BUDGET • LONG STAYS

Hotels near a U-Bahn station a few stops out were about €100-130 a night and 15-20 minutes from the centre (2024). Check for station works before you book: some lifts and the central S-Bahn are closed this winter.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [Traveling Butler](#), [Creative Travel Guide](#)

## *Hotels we'd start with*

Wiley Fox may earn a small commission if you book through these links. Your price stays the same.

BY THE STATE OPERA • LUXURY WITH CHILDREN

## *Hotel Sacher Wien*

Next to the Opera and Albertina. The breakfast buffet has a children's stand with treats and colouring books, and the hotel runs a Christmas Sachertorte decorating demonstration (2024).

€€€€ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Sonia Mota: Simply Slow Traveler](#)

KÄRNTNER RING • LUXURY

## *Hotel Imperial*

A 150-year-old palace hotel on the Ring, decorated throughout for Christmas, with its own torte (2024).

€€€€ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Luxury Travel Queen](#)

PARKRING, OPPOSITE THE STADTPARK • FAMILIES

## *Vienna Marriott Hotel*

On the Ring, 5-10 minutes' walk from the cathedral and Kärntner Straße, with an indoor pool for wet afternoons; from about \$311 a night (2023).

€€€ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Tip-top travel tips](#)

NEUBAU, BY BURGGASSE-STADTHALLE U6 • GOOD VALUE

## *Arcotel Wimberger*

By the U6 and trams, a short walk from Mariahilfer Straße, with a spa; from about \$169 a night (2023).

€€ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Tip-top travel tips](#)

LEOPOLDSTADT, BY THE PRATER • FAMILIES ON A BUDGET

## *Hampton by Hilton Vienna Messe*

Near the Messe and the Prater on the U2, with a gluten-free breakfast option; from about \$148 a night (2023).

€€ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Tip-top travel tips](#)

INSIDE WESTBAHNHOF • ARRIVING BY TRAIN

## *Motel One Wien-Westbahnhof*

A design budget hotel inside the station, on the U3 and U6, about 10 minutes from the centre; from about \$118 a night (2023). Busy station area at night - use the main entrances.

€ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Tip-top travel tips](#)

### *Search all Vienna hotels*

Compare live prices, then check the street on the Wiley Fox map before you book.

SEARCH BOOKING.COM

WF

Clip a Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child. If you get separated in the crowd at Rathausplatz or on the U-Bahn, anyone who scans it can contact you straight away - no app needed on their side.

## WHAT CREATORS RATE

## *Ten things worth your time*

Ranked by how often creators recommend them. Book the palaces and Café Central ahead - Schönbrunn and the Hofburg use timed entry and sell out in December.



Photo: Hiroki Ogawa · CC BY 3.0

# 01

### *St Stephen's Cathedral (Stephansdom)*

STEPHANSPLATZ • GREAT FOR KIDS

The Gothic heart of the city, with its patterned tile roof. You can step into the back for free; a guided sightseeing visit costs extra. The North Tower has a lift to the big Pummerin bell; the South Tower is 343 narrow steps. The catacombs tour includes rooms of bones that may upset young children. Sightseeing stops during services and is restricted at Christmas.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [Ultimate Bucket List](#), [Grete the Austrian Guide](#), [Lifestyle Hal](#), [Noah Travel Guides](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#), [Wolters World](#)

*Back of the nave free · visit €8, child €3 · All-inclusive €29 (cathedral site)*

[DETAILS](#)

02

Photo: Thomas Wolf, [www.foto-tw.de](http://www.foto-tw.de) · [CC BY-SA 3.0 de](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/de/)

## Schönbrunn Palace & gardens

HIETZING · GREAT FOR KIDS

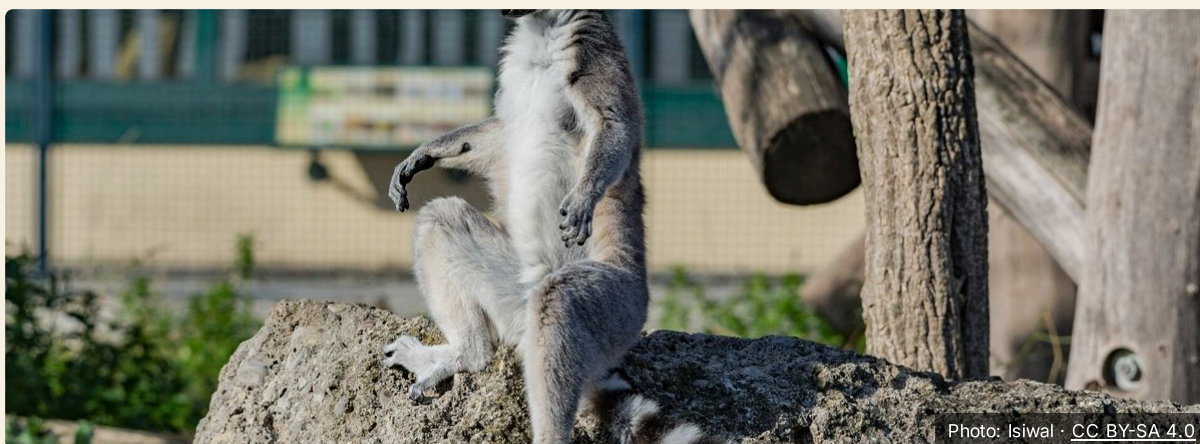
The Habsburg summer palace, with the Christmas market in its courtyard. The gardens are free and the walk up to the Gloriette gives the classic view. Book a timed palace ticket online - the short State Apartments tour is very brief, so creators suggest a longer one. There is a children's museum with dress-up.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [Carol & Max](#), [Wolters World](#), [Happy to Wander \(Travel Tips & Inspo\)](#), [The Traveler's Atlas](#), [Exotic Vacation](#), [Sonia Mota: Simply Slow Traveler](#)

*Gardens free · palace from €30 adult, €20 child (2026 summer prices)*

[DETAILS](#)

03

Photo: Isiwal · [CC BY-SA 4.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/)

## Tiergarten Schönbrunn (the zoo)

HIETZING · GREAT FOR KIDS

One of the oldest zoos in the world, in the palace grounds, with pandas and more than 700 species - a hit with children and open all year.

Via [Island Hopper TV](#), [Noah Travel Guides](#), [Wolters World](#), [Khyati & Puria](#)

*About €27 adult (2025)*

[DETAILS](#)

## 04

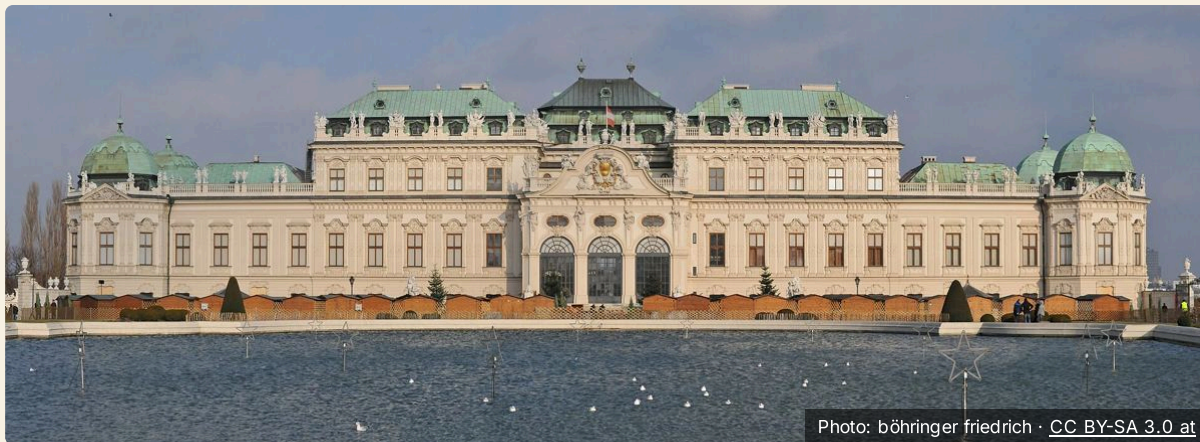


Photo: böhringer friedrich · CC BY-SA 3.0 at

### *Belvedere*

LANDSTRASSE • GREAT FOR KIDS

Baroque palaces with free gardens and Klimt's *The Kiss* in the Upper Belvedere. Timed tickets sell out, so book online; lockers for bags. The small Christmas market sits in front of the Upper Belvedere, and the palace reflected in the pond at sunset is a favourite photo.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [Carol & Max](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#), [Island Hopper TV](#), [Ria SW](#), [The Traveler's Atlas](#)

*Gardens free · Upper Belvedere about €22 (2026)*

DETAILS

## 05



Photo: Dietmar Rabich · CC BY-SA 4.0

### *Prater & the Riesenrad*

LEOPOLDSTADT • GREAT FOR KIDS

The 1897 giant Ferris wheel, 65 m high, best at sunset, and an amusement park that is free to enter - you pay per ride, often in cash. In winter the Riesenradplatz hosts a family-friendly market until 6 January, and the Prater Hauptallee is a 4 km car-free walk.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [Grete the Austrian Guide](#), [Island Hopper TV](#), [Noah Travel Guides](#), [Happy to Wander \(Travel Tips & Inspo\)](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#)

*Riesenrad from €14.50 online (2026) · park free*

DETAILS

06



## ***Natural History Museum***

MARIA-THERESIEN-PLATZ · GREAT FOR KIDS

Dinosaurs, interactive displays and a digital planetarium - creators call it very entertaining for children, and it faces the Christmas market. Under-19s go free at many Vienna museums; bring ID.

Via [Ultimate Bucket List](#), [Lifestyle Hal](#), [Carol & Max](#)

*Under 19 free*

DETAILS

07



## ***Haus des Meeres***

MARIAHILF · GREAT FOR KIDS

Austria's largest aquarium, inside a wartime flak tower, with sharks, a 10 m tunnel and a rooftop terrace on the 11th floor - a good warm, indoor morning with children.

Via [Noah Travel Guides](#)

*Check the site*

DETAILS

08



## *Hofburg, Spanish Riding School & the Ring*

INNERE STADT • GREAT FOR KIDS

The imperial palace complex. The Lipizzaner horses' morning exercise is the cheap way in; full performances sell out weeks ahead, and under-3s are not admitted. Then walk or take tram 1 round the Ringstraße past the Opera, Parliament and City Hall.

Via [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#), [Grete the Austrian Guide](#), [Khyati & Puria](#)

*Morning exercise from €17 · performances from €26*

DETAILS

09



## *State Opera standing tickets*

OPERNRING

Standing places for the State Opera are sold on the day, about 80 minutes before the performance, for around €13-18 - the cheapest way to see a show. Buy seated tickets only from the official site, never from street sellers.

Via [VIENNA CALLING - Travel Guide](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Grete the Austrian Guide](#), [Ultimate Bucket List](#)

*Standing about €13-18 (2023)*

DETAILS

10



## *Albertina*

ALBERTINAPLATZ • GREAT FOR KIDS

Creators' best-value museum, with state rooms and a terrace view over the Opera. Under-19s free.

Via [Happy to Wander \(Travel Tips & Inspo\)](#)

*Under 19 free*

DETAILS

## *If you only have one day*

ONE

1

### *The classic loop*

- 08:00 **Café Central at opening.** Breakfast before the queue, then the Hofburg courtyards.
- 09:30 **St Stephen's Cathedral.** Inside, then the North Tower lift - before the crowds and services.
- 11:00 **Am Hof and Freyung markets.** The calmer old-town markets, five minutes apart.
- 12:30 **Lunch.** Schnitzel or a Würstelstand Käsekrainer.

- 14:00 **Natural History Museum.** Dinosaurs for the children, then Maria-Theresien-Platz market outside.
- 16:00 **Rathausplatz at dusk.** The skating trail, the children's world in the park and the flying-heart show - weekday if you can.
- 18:30 **Spittelberg.** Dinner at the stalls in the lanes, then tram or U-Bahn home.
- 

## *Three days, grouped by area*

### DAY

# 1

## *The old town*

- AM Café Central, cathedral and Hofburg.
- PM Am Hof, Freyung and Stephansplatz markets; the Graben chandeliers.
- EVE Rathausplatz and Spittelberg in the evening.
- 

### DAY

# 2

## *Palaces*

- AM Schönbrunn Palace (timed ticket) and the zoo.
- PM Schönbrunn Christmas market and the Gloriette walk.
- EVE Belvedere market and The Kiss.
- 

### DAY

# 3

## *Families and the Prater*

- AM Art Advent at Karlsplatz (opens noon) or Haus des Meeres.
- PM Prater, the Riesenrad and the winter market.



## SCHNITZEL, KÄSEKRAINER AND KAISERSCHMARRN

## Where to eat

Vienna eats hearty: Wiener schnitzel with potato salad, Tafelspitz (boiled beef), goulash, and sweet things such as Kaiserschmarrn (torn pancake with plum sauce), Sachertorte and strudel. Sausage stands (Würstelstände) sell Käsekrainer - a cheese-filled sausage that squirts when you bite it - for a few euros. Famous places queue, so book or go early. Prices carry the year.

### *Café Central*

HERRENGASSE • COFFEE HOUSE

€€

The grand coffee house everyone wants: the queue wraps round the building by mid-morning. Book the 8:00 slot online or arrive at opening; the café in Passage Ferstel next door is a calmer fallback.

Family friendly

Via [GoAnnieWhere](#), [Sophie Nadeau](#), [Jess Ellis](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Finding Gina Marie](#) – [Travel the World](#)

VISIT

### *Café Demel*

KOHLMARKT • CAFÉ &amp; CAKE

€€

Kaiserschmarrn and coffee near the Hofburg. Queues can be an hour; the takeaway counter is a quick way to get a portion.

Family friendly

Via [Traveling Expats](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [Carol & Max](#)

VISIT

### *Café Sacher*

BY THE STATE OPERA • CAFÉ &amp; CAKE

€€€

The original Sachertorte, €10.50 a slice with cream (2025). Creators found the queue long and the cake overrated - Café Mozart nearby serves it with fewer tourists.

Family friendly

Via [Borja Ilegó](#), [Wolters World](#), [Worthy Travels](#), [Chalk & Cheese Travels](#)

VISIT

## *Bitzinger Würstelstand*

BY THE ALBERTINA • SAUSAGE STAND

€

The most famous sausage stand in town, opposite the Opera - Käsekrainer, bratwurst and Leberkäse late into the night. A Käsekrainer, frankfurter and bread for two came to just over €17 (2026).

Family friendly

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [Carol & Max](#), [Wolters World](#)

VISIT

## *Plachutta*

WOLLZEILE • VIENNESE

€€€

Popular with locals and visitors for Tafelspitz and schnitzel; book ahead.

Family friendly

Via [Khyati & Puria](#)

VISIT

## *Zum Schwarzen Kameel*

BOGNERGASSE • VIENNESE DELI

€€

A chef's daily lunch spot: open sandwiches, ham with horseradish and finger-food schnitzel in a classic setting.

Family friendly

Via [Condé Nast Traveler](#), [Sonia Mota: Simply Slow Traveler](#)

VISIT

## *Naschmarkt*

WIEDEN / MARIAHILF • FOOD MARKET

€-€

€

More than 100 stalls for a casual lunch; touristy and pricey for groceries, busier after midday. Locals prefer Brunnenmarkt (tram 2) for value.

Family friendly

Via [Carol & Max](#), [Jess Ellis](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [VIENNA CALLING - Travel Guide](#), [The Traveler's Atlas](#)

VISIT

## *Hotel Imperial café*

KÄRNTNER RING • CAFÉ & CAKE

€€€

The Imperial Torte (€11 in 2024) in a hotel dressed for Christmas.

Family friendly

Via [Luxury Travel Queen](#), [Sonia Mota: Simply Slow Traveler](#)

VISIT

## *Duna Kebab*

REUMANNPLATZ • KEBAB



A famous kebab with a long takeaway queue and a shorter one inside for eating in - go by day.

Family friendly

Via Khyati & Puria

VISIT

## *Lange Gasse, Josefstadt*

JOSEFSTADT • STREET OF SMALL FOOD SHOPS



Melted-cheese rolls (€5.80), a lunchtime-only pizza window (€5) and the Knödel Manufaktur for filled dumplings (€8.90 for two) - all 2024 prices.

Family friendly

Via Khyati & Puria

VISIT

For a grown-ups' evening: Glühwein or a fruit Punsch at Spittelberg after work with the locals, curling with a hot drink at the Altes AKH campus market, standing tickets at the Opera, or a Heuriger wine tavern on the city's own vineyards. Spittelberg and the campus market stay open latest. The drinking age is 16 for beer and wine and 18 for spirits; drinking in public is allowed except on public transport and in small zones such as Praterstern. Opening times and menus change, so check before you travel. Wiley Fox is not paid for restaurant listings.

## BEFORE YOU GO

## Getting around Vienna

### *From the airport (changed for 2026-27)*

Rail works run until about the end of October 2027. The cheap option is the REX7 train to the Hauptbahnhof (about 20 minutes, €5.50 adult, €2.80 age 6-14). The S7 currently stops at St. Marx, where you change to tram 18 or 71. The CAT is now a non-stop coach to Wien Mitte (€14.90, under-15s free). A fixed-price taxi was about €42 for up to four people (2025).

Via [Happy to Wander \(Travel Tips & Inspo\)](#), [Carol & Max](#), [Khyati & Puria](#), [The Ultimate Travel Guide](#)

### *Tickets in 2026*

A single is €3.20 on paper or €3.00 in the WienMobil app (age 6-15: €1.60). A 24-hour ticket is €10.20 (€9.70 digital) and a 7-day ticket €28.90 (€25.20 digital). The 48- and 72-hour tickets were scrapped on 1 January 2026, so older videos are out of date. Validate paper tickets before you travel.

Via [Traveling Expats](#), [Grete the Austrian Guide](#), [Carol & Max](#)

### *Children travel free more often than you think*

Under-6s always ride free. Under-15s ride free on Sundays, public holidays and during Vienna's school holidays - carry photo ID. The Vienna City Card (from €19) also lets one child under 15 travel free with the holder.

Via [Grete the Austrian Guide](#)

### *Getting around*

Five U-Bahn lines and about 20 tram lines, with trains every few minutes; the U-Bahn runs all night on Fridays, Saturdays and before holidays. The U4 goes straight to Schönbrunn, the U2 to the Rathaus and MuseumsQuartier, the U1 from Stephansplatz to the Hauptbahnhof. Trams 1 and 2 circle the Ring past the main sights for the price of a ticket. Eating on board is banned. The central S-Bahn (Praterstern to Hauptbahnhof) is closed this winter.

Via [Khyati & Puria](#), [The Traveler's Atlas](#), [Versed](#), [Grete the Austrian Guide](#)

### *Pushchairs and lifts*

Every U-Bahn station is step-free and pushchairs use the marked doors; they are not allowed on escalators. Some lifts are

being replaced this winter (Westbahnhof to 14 December, Keplerplatz to mid-December) - check Betriebsinfo in the app on the day.

Source: Austrian police / official sources

## What it costs

Single ticket, Kernzone Wien (paper / digital)

**EUR 3.20 paper, EUR 3.00 digital; reduced (6 to 15) EUR 1.60 / EUR 1.50**

2026 tariff from 1 Jan 2026

24 hour ticket (24 Stunden WIEN)

**EUR 10.20 paper, EUR 9.70 digital**

2026 tariff (digital price 'from EUR 9.70' on shop page)

7 day ticket (7 Tage WIEN)

**EUR 28.90 paper, EUR 25.20 digital**

2026 tariff

Vienna City Card (24 hours or 7 days)

**from EUR 19.00; one child to 15th birthday free with card holder**

2026 shop price as read 8 Oct 2026; Dec 2026 price not yet confirmed

Airport to city: CAT by premium bus to Wien Mitte

**Single EUR 14.90, return EUR 24.90; under 15 free**

2026 (train replaced by bus until about end Oct 2027)

Airport to city: REX7 / S7 / Railjet

**Adult EUR 5.50; ages 6 to 14 EUR 2.80; under 6 free**

2026 (S7 only to St. Marx until about end Oct 2027)

Punsch (hot spiced fruit drink) at Christmas markets

**EUR 4.50 to EUR 10.50 (cheapest/dearest cup surveyed)**

2024 (latest year found); 2026 not yet confirmed

Glühwein (mulled wine) at Christmas markets

**EUR 4.80 to EUR 7.50; Rathausplatz average about EUR 6.25**

2024 (latest year found); 2026 not yet confirmed

Mug deposit (Häferlpfand)

**EUR 5 at most markets; about EUR 4 Karlsplatz; EUR 3 Spittelberg**

2024 (latest year found); 2026 not yet confirmed

Käsekrainer sausage and roast chestnuts (Maroni)

**Not yet confirmed (no reliable current price found)**

not found

Sachertorte slice at Café Sacher (Café Bel Étage)

**EUR 10.50 per slice (cream included)**

Sept 2025; 2026 not yet confirmed

Wiener Riesenrad, adult ticket **from EUR 14.50 online; flexible single ticket EUR 17.00; a second tier 'from EUR 6.50' is listed (child price assumed, label not shown)**  
2026 (page modified 28 Jul 2026); December price not yet confirmed

Schönbrunn Palace Ticket (about 75 min, audio guide) **Adult EUR 42.00; child 6 to 18 EUR 30.00; Classic Pass EUR 49.00 / EUR 36.00**  
Summer season 2026 (27 Mar to 2 Nov); winter 2026/27 prices not yet confirmed

Schönbrunn State Apartments ticket (shorter visit) **Adult EUR 30.00; child 6 to 18 EUR 20.00**  
Summer season 2026; winter 2026/27 not yet confirmed. 'Imperial Tour' is no longer a named ticket on the site

Spanish Riding School, cheapest tickets **Performance from EUR 26; Morgenarbeit from EUR 17; children's tour from EUR 11; 'Briefe ans Christkind' (ages 3 to 11) from EUR 15**  
Price list read 8 Oct 2026, year of prices not printed; December 2026 availability not yet confirmed

St Stephen's Cathedral towers **Official price not yet confirmed. Secondary 2024 source: North Tower EUR 7 adult, EUR 2.50 child; cathedral interior free**  
Aug 2024, secondary source

Wiener Eistraum ice rink (not open at Christmas) **Adult EUR 9.50 online, EUR 10.50 box office; child EUR 6.70**  
Season 22 Jan to 8 Mar 2026; next season not yet confirmed

Albertina museum **Visitors under 26 EUR 17.50; under 19 free (adult price not shown in the excerpt)**  
2026 page as read 8 Oct 2026

Kunsthistorisches Museum **Shop shows EUR 22.00 and EUR 24.00 for an entrance ticket (labels unclear); Masterticket EUR 37**  
2026 page as read 8 Oct 2026; verify before print

Creator prices carry the video date. Anything older than 18 months is marked to check.

## Quick tips

### *Go on weekday afternoons*

Rathausplatz and Stephansplatz are packed on weekend evenings. Go at opening or an hour before closing on a weekday, and use the smaller markets for the rest of the time.

### *Carry cash and coins*

Many stalls, cafés, Prater rides and toilets want cash or coins, some places set a €10-15 card minimum, and the mug deposit is about €3-5. Use a bank cash machine, not Euronet.

### ***Keep the mug - or get the deposit back***

Every market has its own mug (Häferl) with a deposit. Return it to any stall of the same market for the refund, or keep it as a souvenir. Plates may carry a €1 deposit too.

### ***Book palaces and cafés***

Schönbrunn, the Hofburg, the Belvedere and Café Central use timed tickets or queue for an hour in December. Book online a few days ahead.

### ***Plan for Sunday and the holidays***

Most shops close on Sundays and on 25 and 26 December; on 24 December general shops shut at 14:00. Supermarkets in the big stations stay open but get crowded. 8 December is a holiday but many shops open 10:00-18:00.

### ***24 December onwards***

Spittelberg, Am Hof, Freyung, Karlsplatz and Türkenschanzpark end on 23 December. Rathausplatz closes at 18:30 on Christmas Eve and runs on to 26 December; Schönbrunn and the Prater winter market run to 6 January.

WF

Found a cash-only stall, a lift out of order or a street that felt wrong? Drop a community report on the map - it helps the next family.

## THE SMALL THINGS VISITORS WORRY ABOUT

## *Local tips for Vienna*

Every tip here was checked against an official or trusted source (Wiener Linien, the City of Vienna, the market organisers, the Austrian police, gov.uk and others) on the date shown. Rules and prices change, so tap the link to double-check before you travel.

### *Paying for transport*

#### *What does a single ticket cost in Vienna?*

From 1 January 2026 a single trip (Kernzone Wien, one direction, transfers allowed) is EUR 3.20 on paper or EUR 3.00 digital. The reduced single for children aged 6 to 15 is EUR 1.60 (EUR 1.50 digital). Two trips cost EUR 6.40. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

#### *Is there a 48 or 72 hour pass?*

No. The 48 and 72 hour tickets, including the Vienna City Card, EasyCityPass and QueerCityPass versions, were discontinued on 1 January 2026. Use the 24 hour ticket (EUR 10.20, or EUR 9.70 digital) or the 7 day ticket (EUR 28.90, or EUR 25.20 digital).

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

#### *Is a 24 hour pass worth it for a family?*

A 24 hour ticket is per person: EUR 10.20 on paper or EUR 9.70 digital, valid for 24 hours from a start time you choose. Digital tickets are personal and need a photo ID. With children free on many days (see the free-travel tip), single tickets can be cheaper for short trips. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

#### *What is the Vienna City Card and do children get free travel on it?*

The Vienna City Card costs from EUR 19.00 and covers public transport for 24 hours or 7 days plus discounts at museums, cafes and shops. One child up to their 15th birthday (or one dog) can travel free with the card holder. It is personal and cannot be passed on. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

#### *Do small children need a ticket?*

Children under 6 travel free on Wiener Linien, and this continues to the end of the school year in which they turn 6. On ÖBB trains the free age ends on the 6th birthday.

#### **CHRISTMAS** *When do children travel free on Sundays and holidays?*

Children and teenagers up to their 15th birthday travel free on Sundays, public holidays, Vienna school holidays, and 2 and 15 November. Carry photo ID in case you

Ages 6 to 15 need the reduced ticket, with photo ID. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

are asked. The exact dates of the Vienna Christmas school holidays not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***How do I buy tickets on my phone?***

Use the WienMobil app or the WienMobil ticket shop (shop.wienmobil.at). The ticket shows in the app and you pay by credit card. Paper tickets are also sold at machines, Wiener Linien info points, tobacconists (Trafik) and in tram ticket machines. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***Can I tap my bank card to travel?***

Only in a trial. Tap+Ride is a one-year pilot started on 28 May 2026 at 9 U-Bahn stations (including Stephansplatz, Schwedenplatz, Hauptbahnhof and Westbahnhof). Visa and Mastercard, Apple Pay and Google Pay work; you keep the same card to show if checked. Not available on trams or buses.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***Do I have to validate my ticket?***

Paper tickets must be validated before the first journey; validity starts at validation. A single ticket must be started straight after purchase or validation and the trip can last at most 80 minutes with no break in the journey. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***What happens if I am caught without a valid ticket?***

The terms of carriage list a surcharge of EUR 131.60 if paid on the spot, EUR 141.60 within two weeks and EUR 181.60 later, on top of the fare, plus a possible EUR 15 processing fee. Press reports in September 2025 put the fine at about EUR 135. Paying on the spot lets you stay anonymous.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***What is the best way from the airport to the city in 2026?***

The airport trains are disrupted until about the end of October 2027. REX7 runs to Wien Hauptbahnhof in about 20 minutes; the S7 only goes as far as St. Marx, where you change to tram 18 or 71. CAT is now a non-stop bus to Wien Mitte (about 21 minutes). Trains cost EUR 5.50 for adults.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***How much is the CAT airport transfer?***

CAT runs as a premium coach (not a train) to Wien Mitte, about every 12 minutes between 07:00 and 19:00 and every 15 minutes otherwise, until about the end of October 2027. Single EUR 14.90, return EUR 24.90 (return valid 6 months). Children under 15 travel free. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***What does the cheap train from the airport cost for a family?***

The REX7, S7 and ÖBB Railjet ticket is EUR 5.50 for adults (EUR 2.30 airport to city boundary plus EUR 3.20 within Vienna). Ages 6 to 14 pay EUR 2.80; under 6 free. If you already hold a Vienna multi-day ticket you only need the EUR 2.30 airport ticket.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

### ***Are there train closures in the city this winter?***

Yes. From 7 September 2026 to the end of October 2027 the central S-Bahn section between Praterstern and Wien Hauptbahnhof is closed to all rail services. Use the U-Bahn, trams or buses instead.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

### ***Can I take a pushchair on the U-Bahn and tram?***

Yes, using the marked entrances and spaces, with the brake on and the straps fastened. Pushchairs must not go on escalators; double pushchairs use the wheelchair entrances. Many trams now have no step; on older ones the driver helps where possible. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***Are U-Bahn stations step-free and which lifts are out?***

Wiener Linien says all U-Bahn stations are reachable step-free. Planned 2026 lift works include Westbahnhof U6/U3 (4 May to 14 December, at least one lift per platform stays open) and Keplerplatz U1 (19 October to mid-December). Check Betriebsinfo on the day. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***Can I bring a dog on public transport?***

Yes, with a reduced single ticket for the dog (free for annual pass holders). Dogs not in a closed carrier need a lead and muzzle, including in station lifts. Small dogs in a proper carrier need no ticket.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

## ***Water & snacks***

**CHRISTMAS** ***What does a Punsch or Glühwein cost and what is the mug deposit?***

**CHRISTMAS** ***Do I get the deposit back and is there a child drink?***

You get the deposit back when you return the mug, or you can keep it (travel blog,

In 2024 Punsch ranged EUR 4.50 to EUR 10.50 and Glühwein EUR 4.80 to EUR 7.50 (Rathausplatz average Glühwein about EUR 6.25). The Häferl deposit was EUR 5 at most markets, about EUR 4 at Karlsplatz and EUR 3 at Spittelberg. 2025 and 2026 prices not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

year not stated). In 2023 Spittelberg sold Kinderpunsch at EUR 2.20 (basic Punsch EUR 4.20) with a EUR 2 mug deposit. Check the price board before you order.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### ***Is the tap water safe to drink?***

Yes. Austrian tap water is safe, tested regularly, and Vienna's comes mostly from mountain springs in the Rax, Schneeberg and Hochschwab areas. Historic decorative fountains are not for drinking. Whether the public drinking fountains run in December not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

## ***Toilets***

### ***Are public toilets free in Vienna?***

Mostly. City-run toilets (167 sites, over 80 percent free) charge EUR 0.50 for a cabin at paid sites and urinals are free; many paid sites are free at night. Wiener Linien toilets in the Öffi network charge at the entrance, amount not yet confirmed. Carry a few coins. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

## ***Parks & play***

### **CHRISTMAS** ***What can children do at the Rathausplatz market?***

The Weihnachtswelt in Rathauspark has a 12 metre multi-level carousel, a reindeer train, a nativity trail (Krippenpfad), a children's hut and its own ice rink. The old Christkindlwerkstatt crafts workshop at the Rathaus was closed years ago, and a 2026 Kinderwerkstatt not yet confirmed.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### **CHRISTMAS** ***Is there a children's activity at Schönbrunn market?***

Schönbrunn market lists a carousel, a Ferris wheel, a children's railway and a craft workshop (Bastelwerkstatt). No workshop hours or prices are given, so check the market's own site. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### *Where are good playgrounds in the city centre?*

Wien.info lists the MuseumsQuartier courtyard, Stadtpark, Rathauspark, Liechtensteinpark and Augarten in the centre, plus the Labyrinthikon playground in Schönbrunn park. Water playgrounds are summer only. In winter the Prater Jesuitenwiese hill becomes a sledge run with snow cannon. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### **CHRISTMAS** *What can we do with children at the Spanish Riding School?*

Besides the performance (from EUR 26) and Morgenarbeit (from EUR 17), there is a children's tour for ages 3 to 11 from EUR 11 and 'Briefe ans Christkind' for ages 3 to 11 from EUR 15. The Christkind programme page carried a 2025 picture, so 2026 dates not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

## *Money & tipping*

### **CHRISTMAS** *Do markets and stands take cards?*

Police advise carrying little cash and paying by card where possible, but which stands accept cards not yet confirmed. Some cafes in Vienna are cash only, usually with a sign. Carry some euros in small notes and coins for mug deposits and snacks.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### *How much should I tip?*

Tip about 5 to 15 percent, usually by rounding up. Say the total you want to pay when you hand over the money (for a EUR 6.50 bill with a EUR 10 note, say 'eight'); do not leave coins on the table. Tip hotel cleaning staff when you leave.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### **CHRISTMAS** *Are shops open on Sundays and on 8 December?*

Most shops close on Sundays; large railway stations, the airport and museum shops stay open. On 8 December 2025 (a public holiday) shops such as Hofer, dm and big malls opened 10:00 to 18:00; 8 December 2026 is a Tuesday and the 2026 list not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### **CHRISTMAS** *What are the opening hours of the main Christmas market?*

The Christkindlmarkt on Rathausplatz runs daily from Friday 13 November to Saturday 26 December 2026, 10:00 to 22:00, closing at 18:30 on 24 December. Whether entry is free in 2026 is not stated on the official page. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

## Phones & data

### *Will my UK phone roam for free in Austria?*

Not guaranteed. UK networks set their own rules and some charge a daily fee in the EU. Ofcom says providers must publish roaming charges, send a text on arrival and let you set a spending limit. Check your own network's rates before you go; the current network rates are not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

## Safety habits

### **CHRISTMAS** *Is Vienna safe from pickpockets at Christmas markets?*

Crime is generally low, but the FCDO warns of pickpocketing in city centres and parks after dark. Vienna police warned in November 2025 of distraction theft in crowds, stalls and queues. Keep bags zipped and in front, and carry little cash.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### *Which places need extra care in the evening?*

Praterstern is a weapons-ban zone from 7 September to 7 December 2026 unless lifted or extended earlier. The FCDO advises care on public transport and at stations. We found no official source naming Karlsplatz or the Gürtel for evening risk, so we make no claim on them. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### **CHRISTMAS** *Is there a terrorism risk?*

The FCDO says terrorists are likely to try to carry out attacks in Austria, including at transport hubs and events. Police presence is higher in Advent; police said in November 2025 there was no specific threat to the markets. Follow staff instructions and stay alert. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

### *What are the emergency numbers?*

112 for any emergency (the 112 Where Are U app also works), 133 for police, 144 for an ambulance, 122 for the fire brigade. For help from the UK government call the FCDO on +44 20 7008 5000. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

## Local ways

### **CHRISTMAS** *When do the other main markets open in 2026?*

### *What are the passport and border rules for UK travellers?*

Schönbrunn 6 Nov to 6 Jan; Stephansplatz 6 Nov to 26 Dec; Spittelberg 13 Nov to 23 Dec; Am Hof 13 Nov to 23 Dec; Belvedere 20 Nov to 31 Dec. Most close early on 24 December (Schönbrunn 16:00, Stephansplatz 16:00, Belvedere 17:00).

Checked 2026-10 ↗

Your passport must be issued less than 10 years before you arrive and valid for at least 3 months after you leave. You can stay 90 days in any 180 without a visa. At the border you may be asked for proof of accommodation, travel insurance, a return ticket and enough money. Checked 2026-10 ↗

### ***What is the EES and will it slow us down?***

The EU Entry/Exit System started on 12 October 2025. On your first visit you may be asked for fingerprints and a photo at a booth; it is free and children aged 11 or younger are photographed but not fingerprinted. Allow extra time at arrival and departure. Checked 2026-10 ↗

### ***Do we need ETIAS for December 2026?***

GOV.UK says ETIAS is expected from autumn 2026 but the EU has not announced the start date, no action is needed yet, the fee will be EUR 20, and any website selling it now is fraudulent. Press reports of a delay to 2027 could not be confirmed. Check GOV.UK again before travel.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

### **CHRISTMAS** ***What is the weather like in December?***

Cold and often grey. Snow on 24 December is now rare: Vienna Hohe Warte recorded snow cover on 24 December in 2 of the 10 years in each decade from the 1980s to the 2010s, and none from 2020 to 2024. An average December temperature not yet confirmed; pack layers and waterproof shoes. Checked 2026-10 ↗

### **CHRISTMAS** ***Can we set off fireworks on New Year's Eve?***

No. Within Vienna the city bans firecrackers, rockets and other pyrotechnics (reported for New Year's Eve 2023). The Silvesterpfad rules for 2026, and advice for dogs on the night, not yet confirmed.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

### **CHRISTMAS** ***What is open on 24, 25 and 26 December?***

Rathausplatz closes 18:30 on 24 December and is open 10:00 to 22:00 on 25 and 26 December; Schönbrunn closes 16:00 on 24 December and runs 10:00 to 19:00 from 25 December. Spittelberg, Am Hof and Karlsplatz end on 23 December. Shop

opening on these days not yet confirmed.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

## *Travel with Wiley Fox*

Official travel advice for 200+ countries, community reports, one-tap SOS, and QR wristbands so lost children and lost bags find their way back.

## Our sources

This guide summarises these creators' videos in our own words. Watch the originals - they are worth it. Crime data: Bundeskriminalamt - Kriminalpolizeiliche Anzeigenstatistik 2025 (Jan 2025 to Dec 2025). Federal criminal police report on offences reported in 2025 (published 31 March 2026), Statistik Austria provisional population 1 January 2026, Landespolizeidirektion Wien weapon-ban orders (2026), Interior Ministry and police statements on the Advent markets (November 2025), press reports of the New Year's Eve 2025/26 trail, and FCDO Austria advice (11 August 2026). Rates are per resident, not adjusted for visitors; no street-level data is published.

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